Do U.S. Presidential Elections Shape Deportation Patterns?

Evidence from State-Level Panel Data, 2004–2019

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Abstract

This thesis studies whether the partisan outcomes of U.S. presidential elections are associated with the intensity and composition of deportations across states. I build a panel of 50 states over 2004–2019 that combines removal records of U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), obtained through the Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse (TRAC), with state-level returns of the 2004, 2008, 2012 and 2016 presidential elections. Using models with state and year fixed effects, economic and crime controls, and standard errors clustered by state, I find that states where the Democratic vote rises relative to the adult population record fewer removals per adult, both of individuals without a criminal conviction and of convicted individuals. A rising Republican vote is associated with more removals, a pattern driven by non-conviction removals. The associations are statistically significant at the 10 percent level once standard errors account for correlation within states, and I find no reliable association for removals of Mexican, Guatemalan, Honduran or Salvadoran nationals. I discuss why these estimates should be read as conditional associations rather than causal effects.

Keywords: deportations, immigration enforcement, presidential elections, partisanship, panel data.
JEL codes: D72, F22, K37.

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1 Introduction

Few policy areas are as politically charged in the United States as immigration enforcement. Deportations regularly occupy the headlines, and candidates' positions on immigration can shape their electoral fortunes. A large literature studies how immigration affects voting (Mayda, 2006; Mayda et al., 2016; Dustmann et al., 2019; Otto and Steinhardt, 2014). Much less is known about the reverse link: whether the political outcomes of elections are reflected in how intensively the state removes non-citizens. This thesis asks whether the partisan outcomes of U.S. presidential elections are associated with the level and composition of deportations across states.

The question matters for at least two reasons. First, deportation is a sanction whose use depends heavily on administrative discretion. Federal law defines who is removable, but how many people are actually apprehended and removed depends on enforcement priorities, on cooperation between federal agencies and state and local law enforcement, and on the political climate in which these actors operate (Morawetz, 2000; Ellermann, 2005; King et al., 2012). Second, the composition of removals has changed markedly over the last two decades. Between 2004 and 2019, annual removals more than doubled before falling back, and the share of removals of individuals with a criminal conviction swung from about one third to close to two thirds of the total. Understanding whether these patterns vary with the partisan leanings of states helps clarify the political economy of immigration enforcement.

To study this question, I build a state-level panel covering the 50 states between 2004 and 2019. Deportation data come from ICE removal records obtained by the Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse (TRAC) at Syracuse University, which report annual removals by state and distinguish between individuals with and without a criminal conviction. Electoral data come from the MIT Election Data and Science Lab and cover the four presidential elections held in the period: 2004, 2008, 2012 and 2016. My main explanatory variables are the votes received by the Democratic and Republican candidates in each state, expressed relative to the state's adult population. I estimate panel models with state and year fixed effects, so that the estimates compare how removals change within a state as its partisan vote changes, net of national shocks common to all states, and I control for state economic conditions and crime.

I find a consistent pattern. States where the Democratic vote rises record fewer removals per adult, and this holds for removals of individuals without a criminal conviction and, to a lesser extent, of convicted individuals. States where the Republican vote rises record more removals, and this association is concentrated among non-conviction removals. The coefficients are precisely estimated with conventional standard errors, but once standard errors are clustered by state to account for serial correlation, they are sig-

nificant only at the 10 percent level. I find no reliable association when I look separately at removals of Mexican, Guatemalan, Honduran and Salvadoran nationals.

These results should be read as conditional associations. Presidential vote shares are not randomly assigned, deportations may themselves affect voting, and several state characteristics that change over time are not observed. I discuss these issues in detail and outline what further research would be needed to move towards a causal interpretation.

This thesis contributes to the literature in two ways. It brings together two strands that are usually studied separately: work on the determinants and consequences of deportation, and work on the relationship between immigration and electoral outcomes. It also provides descriptive evidence, at the state level, on how the composition of removals between criminal and non-criminal cases relates to partisan outcomes, a dimension that the literature has mostly examined at the national level (King et al., 2012).

The rest of the thesis is organized as follows. Section 2 reviews the background and related literature. Section 3 describes the data. Section 4 presents the empirical strategy. Section 5 reports the main results and Section 6 the extensions. Section 7 discusses the limitations of the analysis and Section 8 concludes.

2 Background and related literature

2.1 Deportation policy in the United States

Only non-citizens can be deported, so naturalized immigrants are not at risk of removal. In practice, non-citizens enter removal proceedings through two main routes: apprehension at or near the border, and identification in the interior, often after an arrest for a criminal offense, when their immigration status is checked.

Federal deportation policy took shape in the late nineteenth century, when the first restrictive laws targeted Chinese laborers (Hester, 2017). Over the twentieth century, deportation became a tool of social and labor-market control as much as of immigration policy. Large campaigns such as "Operation Wetback" in 1954 targeted Mexican workers, both documented and undocumented (Ngai, 2003), while programs such as the Bracero Program brought Mexican guest workers to the United States to address wartime labor shortages (Ellermann, 2005). This alternation between recruitment and removal is a recurrent feature of U.S. immigration policy.

More recently, enforcement has increasingly targeted individuals with criminal records. Programs administered by ICE in cooperation with state and local law enforcement, such as the Criminal Alien Program, are designed to identify removable non-citizens in jails and prisons, and the county-by-county rollout of Secure Communities between 2008 and 2013

extended immigration checks to everyone booked into local jails (Cox and Miles, 2013). The 1996 immigration reforms had already broadened the set of offenses that make a non-citizen removable and limited judicial discretion (Morawetz, 2000). Removal policy has also been used as an instrument of crime control beyond U.S. borders: deportations of gang members contributed to the spread of gangs in Central America (Arana, 2005; Cruz, 2013), and governments in the region responded with "zero tolerance" policies (Gutiérrez Rivera, 2010). U.S. criminal deportations have also been shown to affect human capital in the receiving countries (Sviatschi, 2019).

Enforcement has consequences for the communities that remain. Deportation-related family separations affect the well-being of Latino children and youth (Lovato et al., 2018), and fear of deportation has grown in the Latino community, including among U.S.-born citizens of Latino descent, who are not themselves deportable but whose relatives and neighbors are (Asad, 2020). Deportation policies have also been linked to changes in the health behavior of Latino citizens (Pinedo, 2020) and to the criminalization of immigrants through drug law enforcement (Tosh, 2021).

Figure 1 describes the nationalities of those removed. Four countries, Mexico, Guatemala, Honduras and El Salvador, account for between 81 and 95 percent of all removals in every year of the period. Mexican nationals dominate in levels, peaking at almost 290,000 removals in 2012, but their share of all removals fell from about two thirds in 2004, and more than 70 percent around 2011, to under half by 2019, while removals of Guatemalans and Hondurans grew substantially in the second half of the period. Figure 4 shows the same series at monthly frequency, which reveals sharp spikes in Central American removals around 2013–2014 and again in 2018–2019.

Public perceptions of enforcement do not always match these numbers. Asked which administration had deported more unauthorized immigrants, a plurality of Latinos (41 percent) answered that the Obama administration had deported more than the Bush administration, 36 percent said that both had deported about the same number, and 10 percent said that the Obama administration had deported fewer (Lopez et al., 2011).

2.2 Immigration, public opinion and voting

A well-established literature shows that immigration shapes electoral outcomes. Across countries, attitudes towards immigrants reflect labor-market concerns as well as security and cultural considerations (Mayda, 2006). In Europe, larger inflows of refugees and immigrants are associated with more votes for anti-immigration parties in Denmark (Dustmann et al., 2019; Harmon, 2018; Gerdes and Wadensjö, 2008), Germany (Otto and Steinhardt, 2014), Spain (Mendez and Cutillas, 2014) and Greece (Roupakias and Chletsos, 2020). For the United States, Mayda et al. (2016) find that immigration affects the

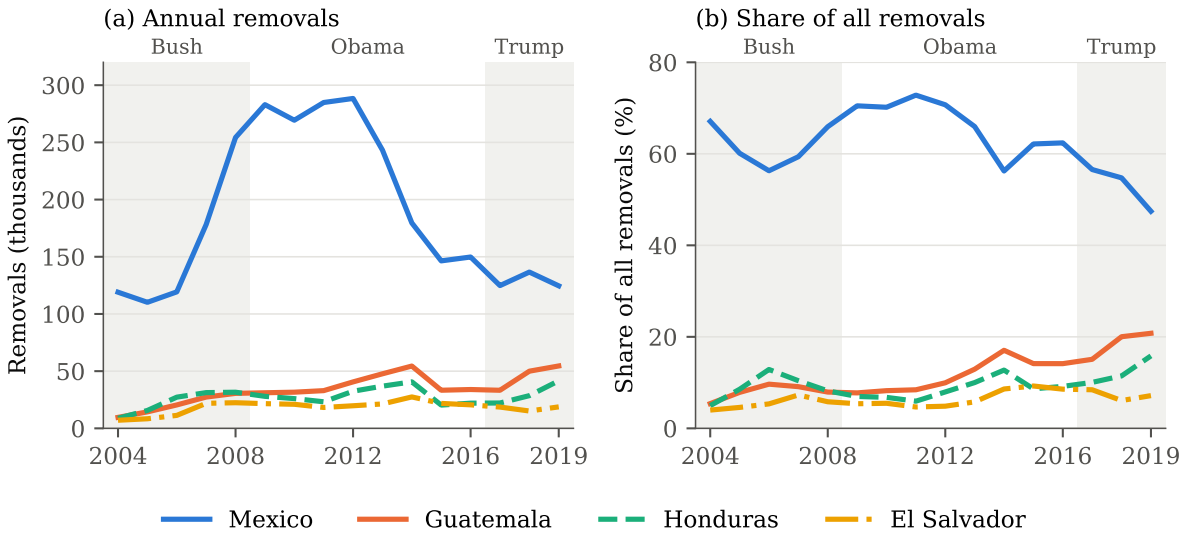


Figure 1: Removals from the United States of nationals of the four main countries of origin, 2004–2019

Notes: Panel (a) reports annual removals by country of citizenship, in thousands. Panel (b) reports each country's share of all ICE removals in the same year. Years are U.S. federal fiscal years (October to September). Shaded areas indicate the administration in office during most of the fiscal year.
Source: ICE removal records obtained by TRAC; author's calculations.

Republican vote share, with effects that differ by the skill composition of immigrants, and Gimpel (2014) discusses how immigration has changed the political prospects of the Republican Party since 1980. Immigration also affects the geographic distribution of voters and representation (Burmila, 2009).

Public opinion is the main channel that links immigration to voting. Economic motivations play a limited role at the individual level, but beliefs about the national economy, anxiety over taxes and general feelings towards Hispanics and Asians, the two largest immigrant groups, are significant determinants of restrictionist sentiment (Citrin et al., 1997). Similar patterns appear in other destination countries (Tienhaara, 1974; Wilkes et al., 2008). Group-status threat has also been emphasized: projections that non-white groups would outnumber whites in the United States by around 2042 increased support for Trump and his anti-immigrant policies among white Americans in the 2016 election (Major et al., 2018). Proximity matters too: Republicans living farther from the U.S.–Mexico border were more likely to support building a wall along the entire border, replacing direct information with partisan beliefs (Cortina, 2020). Whether these patterns extend to Democratic voters, or played a similar role in earlier elections, is less clear.

Immigration also interacts with the debate on the welfare state. Concerns about the fiscal cost of immigrants can shape voter sentiment (Epstein and Hillman, 2003), and immigration can change labor-market competition for native workers (Price et al., 2020). At the same time, immigrants are often associated with crime in political discourse and the media, which reinforces support for enforcement (Tosh, 2021). Both parties

have increasingly addressed foreign-born voters and immigration in their campaigns, and partisan identification among registered voters remains closely balanced, with 48 percent identifying with or leaning towards the Democratic Party and 44 percent towards the Republican Party on the eve of the 2016 election (Pew Research Center, 2016).

2.3 Political institutions and immigration enforcement

A separate literature examines how political institutions shape immigration policy and enforcement. Theories of deportation emphasize that public opinion and political institutions influence the style, intensity and frequency of formal sanctions (Morawetz, 2000). At the state level, immigrant policy is driven mainly by legislative professionalism, the ideology of the electorate, state wealth and changes in the foreign-born population, and immigration rose to the top of state political agendas in the second half of the 2000s (Monogan, 2013).

The closest study to this thesis is King et al. (2012), who analyze U.S. criminal deportations over 1908–2005. They show that deportations rise when economic conditions deteriorate, consistent with the idea that anti-immigrant sentiment is partly rooted in economic conditions (Sniderman et al., 1986; Epstein and Hillman, 2003; Gimpel, 2014). Political discourse on immigration also becomes more salient as the economy worsens and elections approach. Prosecutors and judges operate in this environment, and changes in the legal and political climate can alter the relationship between punishment and politics. At the same time, punitive immigration legislation has often cut across party lines. The Immigration Reform and Control Act of 1986 was passed by a Democratic Congress and signed by a Republican president, and incarceration rates rose for decades under both parties, which suggests that removal reflects a broad security agenda as much as partisan control (Beckett and Sasson, 2000). The relationship between unemployment and imprisonment has also changed over time with the broader economic structure (Michalowski and Carlson, 1999).

2.4 Contribution

Despite these literatures, there is little direct evidence connecting electoral outcomes to deportation patterns. It is not clear whether an increase in Democratic or Republican votes is associated with more, fewer or unchanged removals, nor whether any such association differs between criminal and non-criminal cases. This thesis provides state-level evidence on these questions over 2004–2019, a period that covers the second Bush administration, both Obama administrations and the first years of the Trump administration.

3 Data

I combine several public sources into a balanced panel of U.S. states by year. Table A1 in the Appendix lists every variable, its definition and its source.

3.1 Deportations

Deportation data come from ICE removal records obtained by TRAC at Syracuse University through litigation under the Freedom of Information Act. The records report removals by fiscal year and by state, and classify each removal according to the most serious criminal conviction recorded for the individual, following the National Crime Information Center offense codes of the Federal Bureau of Investigation. I use this classification to split total removals into two groups: *criminal removals*, of individuals with at least one recorded criminal conviction, and *non-conviction removals*, of individuals with no recorded criminal conviction, who are removed for immigration violations such as entry without inspection or presence without valid documents. The two groups add up to total removals.

The records include removals resulting from apprehensions at ports of entry and by the Border Patrol when custody is transferred to ICE, but they exclude removals carried out directly by U.S. Customs and Border Protection. A small number of removals is recorded under locations that are not states (such as Puerto Rico, Guam, "Unknown" or "Outside U.S."); I exclude these observations because no presidential election results exist for them. State–year combinations with no recorded removals are set to zero.

My main outcome is the number of removals per adult, defined as total removals in a state and year divided by the state's population aged 18 and over. I construct the same ratio for criminal and non-conviction removals. In the text, I report these ratios per 1,000 adults to ease interpretation. For the extension by country of origin, I use the number of removals of Mexican, Guatemalan, Honduran and Salvadoran nationals recorded in each state and year.[1]

Figure 2 shows the evolution of total, criminal and non-conviction removals. Total removals more than doubled between 2004 and 2012, from about 174,000 to a peak of 406,000, before falling to about 220,000 in 2017. The composition changed as well. Non-conviction removals drove the increase until 2008, while criminal removals grew steadily between 2008 and 2012. As Figure 3 shows, the share of criminal removals fell from 53 percent in 2004 to 34 percent in 2008, then rose to 57 percent by 2012 and reached 64 percent in 2017 and 2018.

[1] In the source file, the 2006 state-level figures for Guatemala and Honduras are transposed relative to the national totals for that year. I use the version consistent with the national totals.

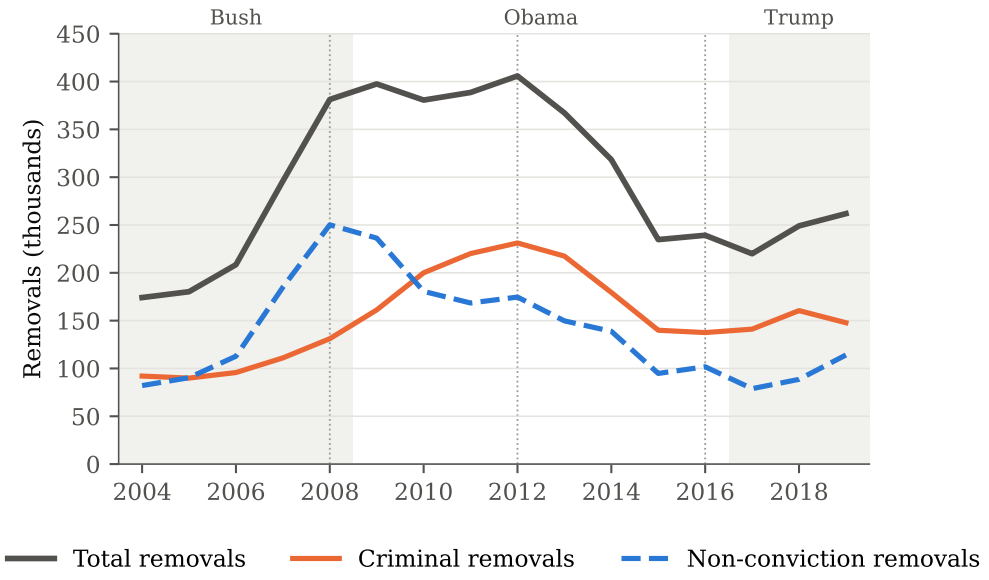


Figure 2: Total, criminal and non-conviction removals from the United States, 2004–2019

Notes: Annual removals in thousands, summed over the 50 states and the District of Columbia. Criminal removals are those of individuals with at least one recorded criminal conviction; non-conviction removals are those of individuals with none. Dotted vertical lines mark presidential election years. Shaded areas indicate the administration in office during most of the fiscal year.

Source: ICE removal records obtained by TRAC; author's calculations.

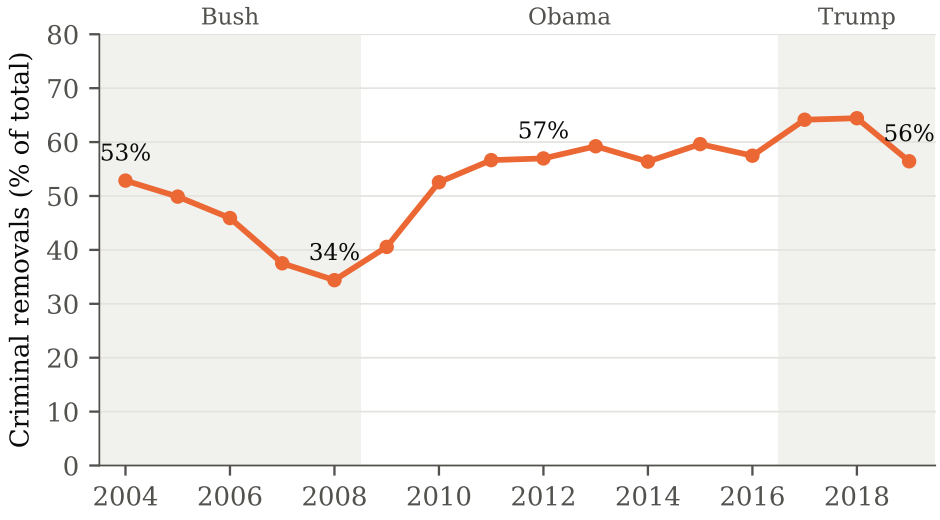


Figure 3: Criminal removals as a share of total removals, 2004–2019

Notes: Criminal removals divided by total removals, summed over the 50 states and the District of Columbia. Shaded areas indicate the administration in office during most of the fiscal year.

Source: ICE removal records obtained by TRAC; author's calculations.

3.2 Presidential elections

Election data come from the MIT Election Data and Science Lab (MIT Election Data and Science Lab, 2017), which reports state-level returns for every presidential election since 1976. I use the four elections that fall within the period covered by the deportation data: 2004, 2008, 2012 and 2016. I restrict attention to the Democratic and Republican candidates, who together received the vast majority of votes in every state and election; third-party and independent candidates do not run consistently across elections and represent a small share of the vote.

My explanatory variables are the votes received by the Democratic candidate and by the Republican candidate in each state, divided by the state's population aged 18 and over. I refer to these as the Democratic and Republican *vote shares*. Because the denominator is the adult population rather than the number of votes cast, each variable reflects both the level of support for the party and electoral participation. Elections take place every four years, while the panel is annual. I therefore assign each election result to the election year and the three following years, so that the 2004 result applies to 2004–2007, the 2008 result to 2008–2011, the 2012 result to 2012–2015 and the 2016 result to 2016–2019.

3.3 Population and control variables

The adult population comes from the Census Bureau's voting and registration tables, which are published every two years. For the years in between, I use the value of the preceding year, since the adult population changes slowly from one year to the next.

I control for state economic conditions and crime. Unemployment rates come from the Bureau of Labor Statistics. Poverty rates come from the Census Bureau's historical poverty tables, based on the Current Population Survey. Real GDP per capita is computed from the real GDP series of the Bureau of Economic Analysis and enters the models in logs; it captures overall prosperity and labor-market conditions, which affect both the location choices of immigrants and attitudes towards them (Etzo, 2011). The poverty rate captures economic hardship, which affects immigrant families in particular (Van Hook et al., 2004; Borjas, 1990). To capture the intensity of criminal activity and of punishment, I use the murder rate per 100,000 inhabitants and an indicator for states with the death penalty, both from the Death Penalty Information Center, which compiles data from the Federal Bureau of Investigation and the Bureau of Justice Statistics. The murder rate is a widely used measure of violent crime because it is less affected by reporting differences than other offense categories (King et al., 2012). These series end in 2018.

3.4 Sample and descriptive statistics

The estimation sample covers the 50 states over 2004–2019. The District of Columbia is excluded because the GDP and crime data are not available for it. The main specification therefore uses 800 observations (50 states over 16 years), and specifications that include the crime controls use 750 observations (50 states over 15 years, 2004–2018).

Table 1 reports descriptive statistics. On average, a state records about 0.66 removals per 1,000 adults per year, with roughly equal shares of criminal and non-conviction removals. The distribution is very skewed: border states account for most removals, and Arizona reaches about 22 removals per 1,000 adults in 2009. The Democratic and Republican candidates each receive votes equivalent to about 30 percent of the adult population on average.

Table 1: Descriptive statistics, estimation sample

	Obs.	Mean	Std. dev.	Min.	Max.
Removals					
Total removals per 1,000 adults	800	0.66	2.36	0.00	21.89
Non-conviction removals per 1,000 adults	800	0.33	1.25	0.00	14.64
Criminal removals per 1,000 adults	800	0.34	1.18	0.00	9.04
Total removals (number)	800	5,849	23,458	0	203,674
Removals of Mexican nationals	800	3,751	16,908	0	155,710
Removals of Guatemalan nationals	800	676	2,991	0	37,717
Removals of Honduran nationals	800	539	2,553	0	29,352
Removals of Salvadoran nationals	800	359	1,608	0	14,781
Presidential elections					
Democratic vote share (% of adults)	800	29.23	7.44	13.09	46.06
Republican vote share (% of adults)	800	30.71	5.87	12.66	45.31
Controls					
Adult population (millions)	800	4.25	4.40	0.37	25.53
Unemployment rate (%)	800	5.65	2.11	2.30	13.70
Poverty rate (%)	800	12.68	3.40	3.70	25.80
Real GDP per capita (thousands)	800	50.69	9.83	32.32	80.05
Murder rate (per 100,000)	750	4.56	2.28	0.83	14.56
Death penalty state (0/1)	800	0.64	0.48	0.00	1.00

Notes: The sample covers the 50 states over 2004–2019. The murder rate is available until 2018. Vote shares are votes for each party's presidential candidate divided by the state's population aged 18 and over. Real GDP per capita is in thousands of chained U.S. dollars.
Sources: ICE removal records obtained by TRAC; MIT Election Data and Science Lab; U.S. Census Bureau; Bureau of Labor Statistics; Bureau of Economic Analysis; Death Penalty Information Center.

4 Empirical strategy

My goal is to estimate how removals change within a state when the vote for a given party changes, net of national shocks and of observable state conditions. Annual state-level data have both a cross-sectional and a time dimension, which allows me to account for unobserved characteristics of states that do not change over time, such as their geography, their distance to the Mexican border or long-standing immigrant networks, and for shocks that hit all states in the same year, such as changes in federal enforcement priorities.

My baseline specification relates total removals per adult to the vote share of each party, conditional on state economic conditions:

$$TDP_{st} = \beta V_{st}^{p} + X_{st}'\delta + \alpha_s + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{st}, \tag{1}$$

where TDP_{st} is the number of removals per adult in state s and year t, V_{st}^{p} is the vote share of party $p \in \{D, R\}$ (Democratic or Republican) in the most recent presidential election, X_{st} is a vector of economic controls (the unemployment rate, the poverty rate and the log of real GDP per capita), α_s are state fixed effects, γ_t are year fixed effects and ε_{st} is the error term. The coefficient of interest is β.

My second specification adds controls for the intensity of criminal activity and of punishment:

$$TDP_{st} = \beta V_{st}^{p} + Z_{st}'\theta + \alpha_s + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{st}, \tag{2}$$

where Z_{st} contains the economic controls in X_{st} together with the murder rate and an indicator for states with the death penalty. These variables are likely to affect both political preferences and attitudes towards immigration and deportation (Wilkes et al., 2008).

I estimate each equation separately for the Democratic and the Republican vote share, with the within (fixed-effects) estimator. I do not include both vote shares in the same regression, because they share the same denominator and are strongly related through turnout.

The year fixed effects absorb everything that is common to all states in a given year, including the identity of the president, changes in federal enforcement priorities and national economic shocks. The state fixed effects absorb all time-invariant differences between states. As a result, β is identified from changes in a state's vote share across elections relative to the changes observed in other states, and it measures whether states where a party gains ground also see removals change relative to other states. Because vote shares only change when a new election takes place, the identifying variation comes from the three transitions between the four elections in the sample.

Most of the controls vary considerably across states but much less within states over

time, which limits how much they can absorb once state fixed effects are included.

For inference, I report two sets of standard errors. Conventional standard errors assume that errors are independent across observations. This assumption is unlikely to hold here, because the vote share of a state stays constant for four years and removals are persistent, so the errors of a given state are likely to be serially correlated. Ignoring this correlation can lead to standard errors that are far too small (Bertrand et al., 2004). My preferred standard errors are therefore clustered by state, which allows for arbitrary correlation of errors within a state over time and for heteroskedasticity across states. With 50 clusters, this correction is generally considered adequate.

Two features of the variables deserve attention when interpreting β. First, both the outcome and the vote share are divided by the adult population. Ratios that share a denominator can be correlated mechanically (Kronmal, 1993). With state fixed effects, only changes in the adult population within states matter, and these are small. Moreover, a common denominator would push the coefficients of both parties in the same direction, so it cannot by itself explain coefficients of opposite signs. Second, because the denominator is the adult population, the vote shares also move with turnout. Higher turnout raises the vote of both parties, so again a pure turnout effect would move both coefficients in the same direction.

5 Results

5.1 Total removals

Table 2 reports the estimates for total removals per adult. Panel A uses the Democratic vote share and Panel B the Republican vote share. Columns (1) and (2) report the estimates of equation (1), and columns (3) and (4) those of equation (2). Odd columns report conventional standard errors and even columns report standard errors clustered by state.

The Democratic vote share is negatively associated with removals per adult in every specification. The coefficient of -0.0101 in column (1) implies that a 10 percentage point increase in the Democratic vote share, relative to the adult population, is associated with about 1 fewer removal per 1,000 adults. Such a change is large relative to the variation actually observed within states, however. A more informative benchmark is the within-state standard deviation of the Democratic vote share, which is 2.6 percentage points. A change of this size is associated with about 0.26 fewer removals per 1,000 adults, or roughly 40 percent of the sample mean. This magnitude is sizable, but the mean is itself low because most states record very few removals, so the estimate is best read as a statement about the direction and relative strength of the association rather than as a

Table 2: Presidential vote shares and total removals per adult

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: Democratic vote share				
Democratic vote share	−0.0101***	−0.0101*	−0.0102***	−0.0102*
	(0.0019)	(0.0055)	(0.0020)	(0.0057)
R^2 (within)	0.094	0.094	0.093	0.093
Panel B: Republican vote share				
Republican vote share	0.0046**	0.0046*	0.0049**	0.0049*
	(0.0019)	(0.0025)	(0.0021)	(0.0027)
R^2 (within)	0.067	0.067	0.067	0.067
Economic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Crime controls	No	No	Yes	Yes
State and year fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Standard errors	Conv.	Clustered	Conv.	Clustered
Observations	800	800	750	750
States	50	50	50	50

Notes: The dependent variable is total removals in the state and year divided by the population aged 18 and over. Vote shares are votes for each party's presidential candidate divided by the population aged 18 and over, assigned to the election year and the three following years. Economic controls are the unemployment rate, the poverty rate and the log of real GDP per capita. Crime controls are the murder rate and a death penalty indicator; they are available until 2018. Standard errors in parentheses: conventional (Conv.) or clustered by state. $^{*}\,p < 0.10$, $^{**}\,p < 0.05$, $^{***}\,p < 0.01$.

precise prediction for any given state.

The Republican vote share is positively associated with removals. A within-state standard deviation of the Republican vote share (2.2 percentage points) is associated with about 0.10 additional removals per 1,000 adults, or about 15 percent of the mean. The Republican association is therefore smaller in absolute value than the Democratic one.

Adding the crime controls in columns (3) and (4) leaves the coefficients essentially unchanged, even though the sample loses the year 2019. This stability suggests that the associations are not driven by differences in violent crime or in the severity of punishment across states.

Clustering the standard errors by state roughly triples them for the Democratic coefficients and increases them by about one third for the Republican ones. All coefficients remain statistically significant, but only at the 10 percent level. This pattern is consistent with substantial serial correlation within states and shows that inference based on conventional standard errors would overstate the precision of the estimates.

5.2 Non-conviction and criminal removals

Total removals combine two groups whose evolution differed over the period (Figure 2). I therefore estimate the same specifications separately for non-conviction removals,

$$NCD_{st} = \beta\, V^{p}_{st} + W'_{st}\lambda + \alpha_s + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{st}, \tag{3}$$

and for criminal removals,

$$CRD_{st} = \beta\, V^{p}_{st} + W'_{st}\lambda + \alpha_s + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{st}, \tag{4}$$

where NCD_{st} and CRD_{st} are removals of individuals without and with a recorded criminal conviction, divided by the adult population, and W_{st} is either the vector of economic controls X_{st} or the full vector Z_{st}. Tables 3 and 4 report the results. Since $NCD_{st} + CRD_{st} = TDP_{st}$ and the models are linear with the same regressors and sample, the coefficients in equations (3) and (4) add up to those in Table 2.

Table 3: Presidential vote shares and non-conviction removals per adult

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: Democratic vote share				
Democratic vote share	−0.0067***	−0.0067*	−0.0067***	−0.0067*
	(0.0013)	(0.0039)	(0.0014)	(0.0040)
R^2 (within)	0.100	0.100	0.109	0.109
Panel B: Republican vote share				
Republican vote share	0.0033**	0.0033*	0.0036**	0.0036*
	(0.0013)	(0.0017)	(0.0014)	(0.0019)
R^2 (within)	0.075	0.075	0.087	0.087
Economic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Crime controls	No	No	Yes	Yes
State and year fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Standard errors	Conv.	Clustered	Conv.	Clustered
Observations	800	800	750	750
States	50	50	50	50

Notes: The dependent variable is removals of individuals with no recorded criminal conviction in the state and year, divided by the population aged 18 and over. See Table 2 for the definition of the vote shares and controls. Standard errors in parentheses: conventional (Conv.) or clustered by state. $^{*}\,p < 0.10$, $^{**}\,p < 0.05$, $^{***}\,p < 0.01$.

For the Democratic vote share, the negative association holds for both groups. About two thirds of the total coefficient comes from non-conviction removals (−0.0067) and one third from criminal removals (−0.0033). Both coefficients are significant at the 10 percent level with clustered standard errors. Since the two groups have similar means, the association with non-conviction removals is about twice as large as the association with criminal removals, also in proportional terms.

Table 4: Presidential vote shares and criminal removals per adult

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: Democratic vote share				
Democratic vote share	−0.0033***	−0.0033*	−0.0035***	−0.0035*
	(0.0009)	(0.0017)	(0.0009)	(0.0019)
R^2 (within)	0.079	0.079	0.083	0.083
Panel B: Republican vote share				
Republican vote share	0.0013	0.0013	0.0013	0.0013
	(0.0009)	(0.0010)	(0.0010)	(0.0010)
R^2 (within)	0.064	0.064	0.067	0.067
Economic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Crime controls	No	No	Yes	Yes
State and year fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Standard errors	Conv.	Clustered	Conv.	Clustered
Observations	800	800	750	750
States	50	50	50	50

Notes: The dependent variable is removals of individuals with at least one recorded criminal conviction in the state and year, divided by the population aged 18 and over. See Table 2 for the definition of the vote shares and controls. Standard errors in parentheses: conventional (Conv.) or clustered by state. $^{*}\,p < 0.10$, $^{**}\,p < 0.05$, $^{***}\,p < 0.01$.

For the Republican vote share, the picture is different. The positive association is concentrated among non-conviction removals, with a coefficient of 0.0033 that is significant at the 10 percent level with clustered standard errors. The coefficient for criminal removals is about 0.0013 and is not statistically different from zero in any specification. In other words, states where the Republican vote increases see relatively more removals of individuals without a criminal record, but not significantly more removals of convicted individuals.

This asymmetry is consistent with the institutional background. Criminal removals depend largely on arrests and convictions in the criminal justice system, which follow their own dynamics and, as discussed in Section 2, have been pursued by administrations of both parties (Beckett and Sasson, 2000; King et al., 2012). Non-conviction removals, by contrast, depend more directly on enforcement choices, such as the extent of cooperation between local law enforcement and federal immigration authorities, which are more likely to reflect the local political climate (Cox and Miles, 2013). These interpretations are suggestive, however, since the data do not allow me to observe the enforcement decisions that generate each removal.

6 Extensions

6.1 Removals by country of origin

Removals are heavily concentrated among nationals of four countries (Figure 1), whose migration flows and political salience differ. I therefore examine whether the associations hold for removals of each nationality separately, by estimating

$$\ln(1 + R^n_{st}) = \beta\, V^p_{st} + Z'_{st}\theta + \alpha_s + \gamma_t + \varepsilon_{st}, \qquad n \in \{\text{MEX}, \text{GTM}, \text{HND}, \text{SLV}\}, \tag{5}$$

where R^n_{st} is the number of removals of nationals of country n recorded in state s and year t. I use the logarithm of one plus the number of removals because many state–year observations record no removals of a given nationality: the share of zeros ranges from 26 percent for Mexican nationals to 47 percent for Salvadoran nationals. I use the full set of controls and standard errors clustered by state.

Table 5: Presidential vote shares and removals by country of origin

	Mexico (1)	Guatemala (2)	Honduras (3)	El Salvador (4)
Panel A: Democratic vote share				
Democratic vote share	0.511	−5.143	−2.257	−3.252
	(2.329)	(3.073)	(2.092)	(1.988)
R^2 (within)	0.238	0.133	0.151	0.141
Panel B: Republican vote share				
Republican vote share	−1.370	−1.417	−0.050	1.748
	(3.330)	(2.417)	(2.207)	(1.794)
R^2 (within)	0.239	0.125	0.149	0.138
Economic and crime controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
State and year fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	750	750	750	750
States	50	50	50	50

Notes: The dependent variable is the logarithm of one plus the number of removals of nationals of each country recorded in the state and year. See Table 2 for the definition of the vote shares and controls. Standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. $^{*}\,p < 0.10$, $^{**}\,p < 0.05$, $^{***}\,p < 0.01$.

Table 5 reports the results. None of the coefficients is statistically significant at conventional levels. The Democratic coefficients are negative for the three Central American countries, in line with the main results, but they are imprecisely estimated, and the coefficient for Mexico is close to zero. The Republican coefficients have no consistent sign. The lack of precision is not surprising: removals of individual nationalities are concentrated in a small number of states, many observations are zero, and the logarithmic transformation gives the same weight to changes in small and large counts. These results neither confirm nor rule out differences across nationalities, and a more detailed analysis would require

data at a finer geographic level.

6.2 Monthly patterns

Figure 4 plots monthly removals of the four nationalities, with presidential elections and inaugurations marked. The monthly series show that the largest movements are not concentrated around elections or changes of administration. The rise in removals of Mexican nationals starts in 2006, before the 2008 election, and the decline starts in 2013, during the second Obama administration. Removals of Central Americans display sharp spikes in 2013–2014 and 2018–2019, which coincide with large arrivals of families and unaccompanied minors at the southern border. These patterns illustrate why national shocks, which the year fixed effects absorb, account for a large part of the variation in removals, and why the identifying variation in this thesis comes from differences across states.

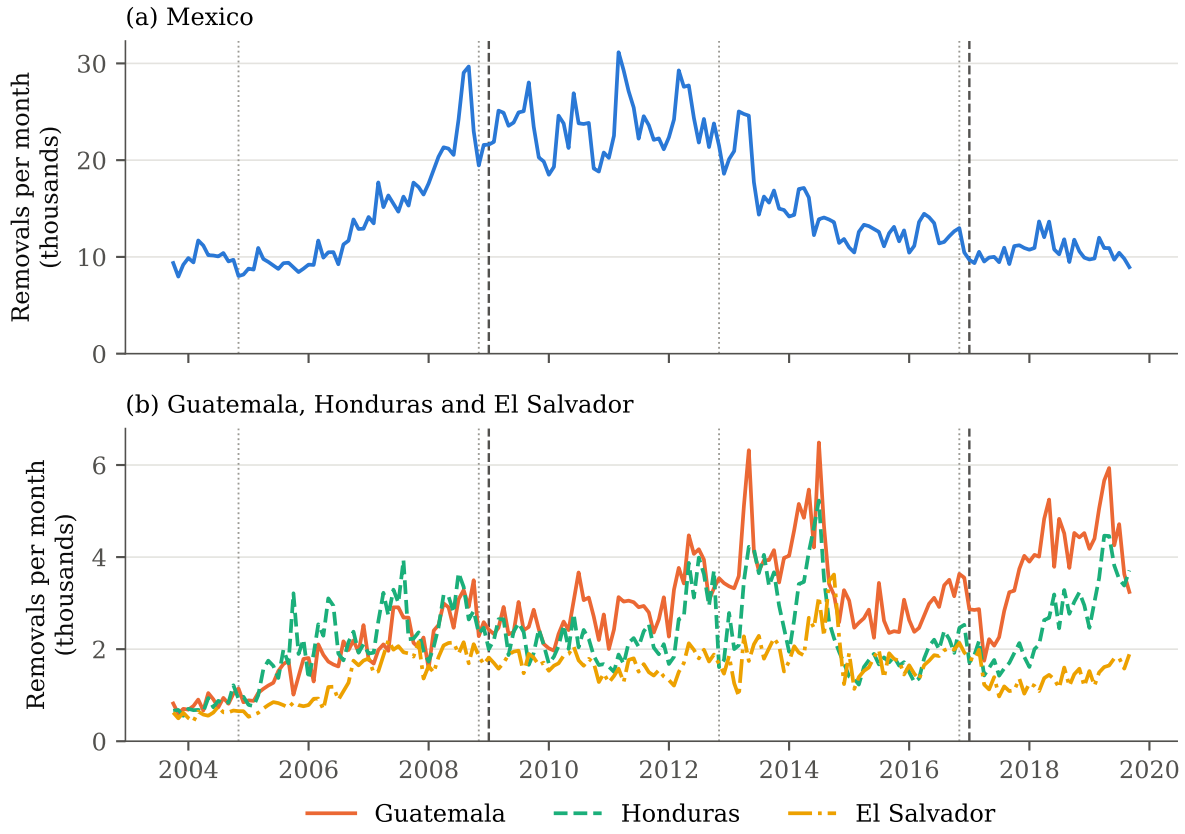


Figure 4: Monthly removals of nationals of the four main countries of origin, October 2003 to September 2019

Notes: Monthly removals in thousands, by country of citizenship. Dotted vertical lines mark presidential elections (November 2004, 2008, 2012 and 2016); dashed vertical lines mark presidential inaugurations (January 2009 and January 2017).
Source: ICE removal records obtained by TRAC; author's calculations.

6.3 Aggregation by presidential term

As an alternative to the annual panel, I also estimated cross-sectional regressions in which the dependent variable is the sum of removals over each four-year presidential term and the explanatory variable is the corresponding vote share. With a single observation per state and term, these regressions cannot include state fixed effects and are very imprecise, so I do not report them.

7 Discussion and limitations

The results point to a consistent association between partisan vote shares and removals across states, but several limitations prevent a causal interpretation.

Reverse causality. Deportations may affect elections as well as respond to them. Intensive enforcement can increase the salience of immigration in political campaigns, mobilize voters who support or oppose enforcement, or change the composition of the electorate in communities affected by removals (Asad, 2020). Panel models with fixed effects do not resolve this problem, and there is no consensus on how to address reverse causality in conventional panel settings (Leszczensky and Wolbring, 2022). The timing of the data adds a further complication: elections take place in November, while fiscal years end in September, so removals recorded in an election year mostly take place before the election whose result is assigned to that year.

Omitted variables. The state and year fixed effects absorb all time-invariant differences between states and all national shocks, but not state characteristics that change over time and are correlated with both voting and enforcement. Examples include the size and composition of the immigrant population, the strength of immigrant networks, changes in state and local immigration policies, and the local rollout of federal programs such as Secure Communities (Cox and Miles, 2013; Monogan, 2013). If, for example, states with growing immigrant populations both shifted towards the Democratic Party and adopted policies that limit cooperation with federal authorities, the estimates would partly reflect these policies rather than electoral outcomes as such. Federal policies, such as the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals program introduced in 2012 (Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman, 2016), are absorbed by the year fixed effects only to the extent that their effects are similar across states.

Controls. The economic controls, in particular unemployment and poverty, may themselves respond to the same forces that drive voting and enforcement. Including them

can absorb part of the relationship of interest or introduce bias. The stability of the coefficients across specifications is reassuring, but it does not rule out this concern.

Measurement. The vote shares are defined relative to the adult population, so they combine partisan support and turnout. The TRAC records exclude removals carried out directly by Customs and Border Protection, which could bias the results if the share of such removals differs systematically across states. The location of each removal is the one recorded by ICE, which may not coincide with the state where the individual lived. Finally, because the adult population is only available every two years, small year-to-year changes in the denominator are not captured.

Inference. The identifying variation comes from only three changes in vote shares per state, and the associations are significant only at the 10 percent level once standard errors are clustered by state. The results should therefore be interpreted with caution.

Further research is needed to move from these associations towards causal estimates. Promising directions include exploiting close elections or other sources of quasi-random variation in partisan control, using more disaggregated data at the county level, where local enforcement decisions are made, and measuring directly the enforcement policies and programs that link electoral outcomes to removals.

8 Conclusion

This thesis studied whether the partisan outcomes of U.S. presidential elections are associated with deportation patterns across states over 2004–2019. Using a panel of 50 states with state and year fixed effects, I find that increases in the Democratic vote, relative to the adult population, are associated with fewer removals per adult, both of individuals without a criminal conviction and of convicted individuals. Increases in the Republican vote are associated with more removals, a pattern driven by removals of individuals without a criminal conviction. The associations are robust to controlling for economic conditions and crime, but they are significant only at the 10 percent level once standard errors account for correlation within states, and they do not appear clearly for removals of individual nationalities.

These findings are consistent with the view that the local political climate matters for immigration enforcement, particularly for the enforcement margin that depends most on discretion: the removal of individuals without a criminal record. They should nonetheless be read as conditional associations. Reverse causality, time-varying omitted factors and the limited number of elections in the sample prevent a causal interpretation. Further research is needed to identify the channels through which electoral outcomes may

shape enforcement, and to assess whether similar patterns arise in other countries with comparable data on deportations.

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Appendix

Table A1: Variable definitions and sources

Variable	Definition	Source
Total removals per adult	Removals recorded in the state and fiscal year, divided by the population aged 18 and over	ICE records via TRAC; U.S. Census Bureau
Non-conviction removals per adult	Removals of individuals with no recorded criminal conviction, divided by the population aged 18 and over	ICE records via TRAC; U.S. Census Bureau
Criminal removals per adult	Removals of individuals with at least one recorded criminal conviction, divided by the population aged 18 and over	ICE records via TRAC; U.S. Census Bureau
Removals by country of origin	Number of removals of Mexican, Guatemalan, Honduran and Salvadoran nationals recorded in the state and fiscal year	ICE records via TRAC
Democratic vote share	Votes for the Democratic presidential candidate divided by the population aged 18 and over, assigned to the election year and the three following years	MIT Election Data and Science Lab; U.S. Census Bureau
Republican vote share	Votes for the Republican presidential candidate divided by the population aged 18 and over, assigned to the election year and the three following years	MIT Election Data and Science Lab; U.S. Census Bureau
Adult population	Population aged 18 and over; available every two years, with the preceding value used in intermediate years	U.S. Census Bureau, voting and registration tables
Unemployment rate	Annual unemployment rate (%)	Bureau of Labor Statistics
Poverty rate	Share of people below the official poverty line (%)	U.S. Census Bureau, historical poverty tables (CPS)
Log real GDP per capita	Log of real GDP divided by total population	Bureau of Economic Analysis; U.S. Census Bureau
Murder rate	Murders per 100,000 inhabitants; available until 2018	Death Penalty Information Center (FBI and BJS data)
Death penalty state	Indicator equal to one if the state has the death penalty	Death Penalty Information Center

Table A2: Summary of results with standard errors clustered by state

Dependent variable	Democratic vote share		Republican vote share	
	Economic controls	Economic and crime controls	Economic controls	Economic and crime controls
Total removals per adult	$-^*$	$-^*$	$+^*$	$+^*$
Non-conviction removals per adult	$-^*$	$-^*$	$+^*$	$+^*$
Criminal removals per adult	$-^*$	$-^*$	$+$	$+$
Mexican removals (log)		$+$		$-$
Guatemalan removals (log)		$-$		$-$
Honduran removals (log)		$-$		$-$
Salvadoran removals (log)		$-$		$+$

Notes: Each cell reports the sign of the coefficient on the vote share and its significance with standard errors clustered by state, based on Tables 2 to 5. $^*p < 0.10$; no star indicates that the coefficient is not significant at the 10 percent level. Removals by country of origin are estimated only with the full set of controls.